

Australia Daily Brief

Saturday, September 19, 2026

1,697 words · 7 min read

RE: Fiji declares HIV emergency · Albanese lands in US for UNSC bid · Canberra skips West Bank sanctions bloc · ADB lends Fiji \$210m · UAE joins PIF as strategic partner

ASX 200

8,731

-0.11%

AUD/USD

0.7121

-0.43%

NZX 50

13,739

+1.17%

NZD/USD

0.5724

-1.51%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Fiji's health ministry declared a national HIV emergency after diagnoses rose twelve-fold since 2010, with only 22 percent of an estimated 9,100 people living with the virus on antiretroviral treatment.
- 2 Anthony Albanese landed in California ahead of the UN General Assembly, where Canberra will formally launch its bid for a 2029-30 UN Security Council seat.
- 3 European diplomats say Australia withdrew at the last minute from a UK-led coalition of a dozen countries moving to sanction trade with Israeli West Bank settlements.

• TOP STORIES

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Diplomats say Australia withdrew from West Bank sanctions coalition at the 11th hour

European diplomats said they were surprised and disappointed when Australia declined to join a *12-country* coalition moving to sanction trade with Israeli settlements in the West Bank. The signatories were the UK, France, Canada, Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Ireland, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Spain, and Sweden. The UK-led statement declared that ethnic cleansing was taking place in the West Bank and that Israel's occupation was unlawful. Canberra took part in the talks but withdrew late, and the government said it was "working closely together towards the same objective" with international partners.

per ABC Politics: "Diplomats reveal how Australia withdrew from sanctions talks at 11th hour"

US-AUSTRALIA

Albanese lands in California as Australia launches its UN Security Council bid

Anthony Albanese arrived in California ahead of the UN General Assembly in New York, where Australia will formally launch its campaign for a non-permanent Security Council seat for the 2029-30 term. The prime minister is expected to use the government's record on digital safety as a selling point. **Penny Wong** also attends. Lobbying is running in parallel over who replaces Secretary-General Antonio Guterres, whose term finishes at the end of the year.

per ABC Politics: "Germany's weapons transformation casts UN manoeuvring in irrelevant light" · also ABC News

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji declares national HIV emergency after twelve-fold rise in diagnoses

Fiji's health ministry declared a national HIV emergency after recording 2,016 new diagnoses in 2025, a twelve-fold increase since 2010, with an estimated 9,100 Fijians now living with the virus, one in every 60 adults. Only 39 percent know their status and just 22 percent are accessing antiretroviral treatment, according to UNAIDS. Health Minister **Antonio Lalabalavu** said the current response level "is no longer sufficient" and called for coordinated action with UNAIDS and the World Health Organization.

per Pacific Island Times: "Fiji declares national HIV emergency amid sharp rise in infections" · also ABC Pacific

• OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[Rudd urges intergovernmental AI regulation ahead of Xi-Trump meeting](#) · ABC Politics

Former prime minister **Kevin Rudd** said there is an urgent need for intergovernmental regulation of artificial intelligence, speaking ahead of next week's Washington meeting between **Xi Jinping** and **Donald Trump**. He canvassed what a set of guardrails involving both the United States and China might look like, and how each would be brought into such a framework.

US-AUSTRALIA

[Trump announces Greenland security deal with Denmark](#) · ABC Politics

Donald Trump said he had struck a deal with Denmark giving the United States "permanent control over security, and all other needs, in Greenland," and that Washington would "immediately" begin developing a larger military presence there. Danish Prime Minister **Mette Frederiksen** said the three governments will sign next week, and that the deal "recognises the sovereignty and territorial integrity" of Greenland and Denmark.

AU-DEFENSE

[ICRC presses for global rules on AI-powered autonomous weapons](#) · ABC Politics

The International Committee of the Red Cross is pushing for new international rules governing AI-powered autonomous weapons in armed conflict. ICRC President **Mirjana Spoljaric** set out the case in an interview with **David Speers** ahead of the UN General Assembly in New York, as AI company executives warn about the technology's broader risks.

AU-POLITICS

[Howard calls immigration 'one of the great Australian achievements'](#) · SMH Federal Politics

Former prime minister **John Howard** described immigration as "one of the great Australian achievements," saying everybody, irrespective of ethnic background, should feel they are part of

Australia. The remarks land in the middle of an intensifying federal argument over migration levels, student visas, and guest worker numbers.

• STAT OF THE DAY

2,016

new HIV diagnoses recorded in Fiji in 2025

A twelve-fold increase since 2010 that prompted Fiji's national HIV emergency declaration, with one in 60 adults now living with the virus.

Pacific Island Times

• AUKUS WATCH

PILLARS 1 AND 2 · THE AUSTRALIAN

Commentary: AUKUS 'isn't a mistake, it's a strategic necessity'

The Australian carried commentary arguing that AUKUS is a strategic necessity rather than a mistake, pushing back on criticism of the submarine partnership's cost and pace. The published text available did not set out the supporting argument in detail.

• PACIFIC WIRE

NIUE · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Niue Ocean Wide Trust named an Earthshot Prize finalist

The Niue Ocean Wide Trust is a finalist for the Earthshot Prize, built on a \$32 *million* endowment funded by Ocean Conservation Commitments sold to individuals, companies, and governments to permanently protect Pacific waters. Vice chair **Coral Pasisi** said the trust wanted finance that "matched the length of that responsibility." Five winners are announced in November in Mumbai, chosen from nearly 7,000 nominations.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Civil society groups warn against rushed Fiji constitutional reform

Fiji's Parliament sits on Tuesday, September 22, to consider the Constitution Review Commission report, with government seeking a new Constitution in force by December 24, also the earliest date the 2026/2027 general election can legally be called. Unity Fiji leader **Savenaca Narube** said "there's no need at all to rush." Five civil society groups warned the timeline risks what they called a "self-coup."

FIJI · FIJI SUN

ADB lends Fiji \$210 million to cushion fuel and food price shocks

The Asian Development Bank will provide Fiji with *US\$210 million*, FJ\$473 million, comprising a US\$200 million policy reform loan and a US\$10 million disaster financing loan. ADB President **Masato Kanda** said "readiness is a duty owed to every family whose livelihood can be upended by the next shock." Regional analysts have warned Fiji's annual fuel import bill could more than double because of the Gulf conflict.

VANUATU · ABC PACIFIC

Thirty-nine missing after MV Matui sinks between Santo and Ambae

Thirty-nine people remain missing after the inter-island ferry MV Matui sank in rough seas last Friday carrying an estimated 55 passengers and crew. Two people have been confirmed dead. A previous passenger described a 12-hour ordeal on the same vessel in 2024, when it arrived at Santo six hours behind schedule in heavy swells. Questions have also been raised over a Vanuatu patrol boat running aground during a government trip.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fiji election observers to examine barriers facing women voters and candidates

The Citizen Observers Group will assess Fiji's election through a peacebuilding and gender lens, not only transparency and credibility. Pacific Centre for Peacebuilding executive director **Florence Swamy** said the group would identify tensions that could re-emerge during the election period. Fiji Women's Rights Movement executive director **Nalini Singh** said observers would weigh the experiences of young, rural, and disabled women.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG marks 51st independence anniversary with grassroots message in Enga

Minister for Transport and Coffee **Miki Kaeok** used Papua New Guinea's 51st independence anniversary to press a message of leadership development, community empowerment, and grassroots engagement in the Wapenamanda District of Enga Province.

• NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · FIJI SUN

Eight-year wait ends for Fijian worker entering New Zealand's RSE scheme

Ratu Isireli Raseisei, 35, was selected for New Zealand's Recognised Seasonal Employer scheme eight years after lodging his application with Fiji's National Employment Productivity Centre. He spent five months in Northland packing and pruning kiwifruit before returning to Fiji on August 28, having worked until then as an administrative officer at Galoa Primary School in Bua.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

NSW Liberals pledge to freeze the state gun buyback before the March election

The New South Wales Liberals will freeze the state's gun buyback and scrap ownership caps for farmers if elected, subject to a commission of inquiry into firearms legislation. NSW was the first state to sign up to the national buyback promised after the Bondi Beach terror attack on December 14, 2025. Police Minister **Yasmin Catley** called it a backflip; party head **Kellie Sloane** tied the changes to the inquiry's findings.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Hard-line conservative Alex Antic wins SA Liberal Party presidency

Alex Antic has won the presidency of the South Australian Liberal Party, shifting the state division rightward. The result comes as the federal Coalition under **Angus Taylor**, leader since February 2026, works through its own positioning on climate and immigration.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Liberal moderate defies Angus Taylor with a call for a carbon tax

A Liberal backbencher has broken with leader **Angus Taylor** to argue for a carbon tax, speaking out on both climate and immigration policy. The intervention comes as the Coalition weighs its emissions position ahead of

COP31 diplomacy.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Northern Territory Aboriginal leaders resign in protest at CLP policies

Several Aboriginal leaders including **Leeanne Caton**, **Rob McPhee**, **Shahleena Musk**, and **Yinjiya Guyula** have resigned from their roles in recent months in protest at Country Liberal Party government policies. Caton, who led Aboriginal Housing Northern Territory, said "every piece of legislation that gets put through has a negative impact directly on Aboriginal people." The CLP has overhauled bail, youth criminal responsibility, and child protection laws since 2024.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · WSJ

Brookfield agrees to \$2.9 billion acquisition of Australia's Reliance

Brookfield has agreed to acquire Australia's Reliance for *\$2.9 billion*, according to the Wall Street Journal. Further terms were not available in the published text.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Western Australia moves to buy back its privatised freight rail network

The Cook Labor government introduced a bill this week to establish a legal framework for returning Western Australia's freight rail network to state control, 26 years after privatisation. The network covers *5,500 kilometres* of track linking the ports of Geraldton, Fremantle, Bunbury, Albany, and Esperance to mining and agricultural regions. The current arrangement dates to a 2000 sale and a 49-year lease of the underlying network.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Sanjeev Gupta's collapse knocks out Australian home builders

The Australian reports that the collapse of **Sanjeev Gupta's** steel interests is hitting Australian home builders and the country's housing pipeline. The published text did not carry figures on the scale of the exposure.

• PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

COMMUNIQUE · THE NATIONAL (UAE)

UAE joins the Pacific Islands Forum as a strategic partner

The United Arab Emirates has been admitted to the Pacific Islands Forum as a strategic partner, a status the Forum grants to outside states seeking structured engagement with its 18 members. Gulf News carried the same announcement.

• UPCOMING

SEP
22

Fiji's Parliament sits to consider the Constitution Review Commission report

Sets whether a new Fijian Constitution can be in force by December 24, the earliest date the next election can be called.

SEP
2026

Xi-Trump meeting in Washington

Any US-China understanding on AI or trade reshapes the environment Canberra and Wellington are hedging in.

SEP
2026

Albanese and Wong at the UN General Assembly, New York

Australia formally launches its campaign for a 2029-30 UN Security Council seat.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether the National-ACT-NZ First coalition continues, and with it current settings on defence and Pacific policy.

NOV
2026

Earthshot Prize winners announced in Mumbai

Niue Ocean Wide Trust is a finalist, with a \$32 million ocean protection endowment model other island states are watching.

• THE WIRE

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

ABC POLITICS

James Curran revisits Paul Keating's vision of an independent Australia

Historian **James Curran**, granted access to **Paul Keating's** papers and a series of interviews, examines the former prime minister's ambition to loosen Australia's remaining attachments to Britain, achieve reconciliation, and reorient the country within Asia.

THE AUSTRALIAN

Xi seeks to exploit Trump's cooling relationship with Taiwan

The Australian reports **Xi Jinping** is looking to capitalise on a cooling in **Donald Trump's** relationship with Taiwan, ahead of the two leaders' Washington meeting.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

FIJI SUN

Fiji's former sugar minister leaves any return to Rabuka

Charan Jeath Singh, now Minister for Multi-Ethnic Affairs, Culture, Heritage and Arts, said any decision to return him to the sugar portfolio rests with Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka**. Current Sugar Minister **Tomasi Tunabuna** confirmed indications of a drop in cane supply to mills on unfavourable weather and high input costs.

AU-POLITICS

THE AUSTRALIAN

How One Nation railroaded Labor's immigration overhaul

The Australian examines how One Nation shaped the passage of Labor's immigration changes, and the electoral exposure the government now carries on migration policy.

SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Migration fix needs economic realism, not scapegoating

The Sydney Morning Herald argues that restoring integrity to a system in which Australia's guest worker economy has ballooned is necessary, but should not involve political scapegoating.

TRADE-ECONOMY

FINANCIAL TIMES

Australia has a secret weapon in the race for AI compute

The Financial Times argues Australia holds an underappreciated advantage in the global competition to build AI compute capacity.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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